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Services to look for when choosing a Lead Company

By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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You drive your affiliate business on sales. And sales are made only after you find leads. When cultivated well, a lead can become a sale or even multiple sales over time. You may think it is impossible to find qualified leads on your own. It is difficult, this is certain, but it is not impossible, especially when you work together with a "lead company," more commonly known as an affiliate network.

A lead company helps calm an affiliate's fear, uncertainty and doubt when navigating the choppy waters of an affiliate marketing campaign. As you prepare, execute and survey the data of your affiliate marketing campaign, you may find the support of a lead company invaluable. Some of the most popular services include the following:

Tracking



Depending on the lead company, a wide range of tracking software services may be available to you as an affiliate. Tracking your leads is an integral element to a successful affiliate marketing career. Each campaign needs to have some order to the swirl of inbound information each lead provides. Lead tracking software provided by your lead company may give you that edge to take your affiliate campaign to the next level.

Dave Roos at Howstuffworks.com provides [the following list](#) of what lead company tracking software might provide:

- Automatically upload sales lead contact information into a database
- Easily update and tag leads through a Web interface
- Assign leads to salesmen by geographical area or product type
- Generate reports on success of different sales campaigns
- Measure return on investment of different marketing techniques
- Automatically collect and import sales inquiries from Web site and other sources for immediate response

Not all lead companies will satisfy this entire list of services. Some companies, such as [Leadtrack](#), focus solely on tracking leads. Companies such as [Lead Lizard](#) incorporate tracking into a larger suite of services that includes lead generation, best practice consulting, campaign management and other services.

Depending on which services each company offers and what services you may need, the company that best fits your situation may not be a fit for the next affiliate. Take a critical look at your budget and campaign to help you decide which leads company to go with, since there will likely be many companies that offer similar services.

Consulting



Perhaps the most proactive service a lead company can offer is lead generation consulting. If you are new to affiliate marketing, then working with a lead company that is willing to talk you through your campaign is invaluable. Different companies provide different types of consulting. Marketo, one of the larger names in leads companies, offers [software](#) to back up consulting.

Marketo's software package helps you publish your content easily, points out SEO and SEM tweaks you may be overlooking and provides social network tools to maximize your reach and site tracking tools. Lead companies usually offer these tools in various formats, but each tool set may be developed specifically for each company's platform. Since finding the right consultant is often a matter of personal taste, it is important for you to develop a clear opinion about each company before deciding to work with any lead company.

Reporting



Metrics help reveal the roadmap to an affiliate marketer's success. Working with a lead company that provides thorough analytical reporting and statistical data will help you see where you're succeeding and where you need to put more effort. Some companies offer individualized reports, and others create annual or semi-annual reports on the market as a whole.

While there is nothing wrong with a company releasing its own annual reports, always remember to keep an eye on a company cherry-picking its data in these reports. Like when a marketing automation lead company releases an annual report proving how valuable marketing automation can be.

A savvy affiliate marketer may notice when a company uses an internal study to rose-tint the lead company's services. This is where doing research before working with a lead company is vital. Make sure the reporting provided to you as an affiliate is valuable to your campaign efforts and your bottom line. After all, you want to work with a lead company that is focused on helping you along with itself.

Takeaway

It is important to remember that lead companies need affiliates as much as affiliates need lead companies. So as you search for a lead company to work with, remember that there are many options to choose from.

Each lead company offers a unique blend of services that may be of interest to you, and some that might not

seem too valuable to your campaign or bottom line. It is up to you to do your research and find the lead company that best fits with your goals as an affiliate marketer.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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